

THE GREAT WAR

World War I quickly escalated into a global conflict because so many of the European powers involved in it had alliances and empires that they were determined to protect.

August 1914 Germany declares war on Russia and France and invades Belgium, triggering Britain to declare war on Germany.

October 15, 1914 There are massive British losses at the **First battle of Ypres**.

February 19, 1915 The **Dardanelles campaign** begins in Turkey.

May 7, 1915 The sinking of the *Lusitania* with many US passengers onboard by a German U-boat causes outrage in the US.

July 1, 1916 **Battle of the Somme** begins, with massive British losses.

April 6, 1917 The US declares war on Germany in response to the sinking of US ships by U-boats.

July 31, 1917 The **Third battle of Ypres**, also known as **Passchendaele**.

November 11, 1918 An armistice is signed in France, ending the war.



1917 was a difficult year for all sides. The Allied naval blockade of Germany and the German U-boat campaign against Allied merchant shipping led to severe food shortages: Germany ran out of wheat flour during the winter, while Britain had run out of sugar by April, and had only enough wheat to last six weeks.

Mutiny and revolution

The French army mutinied in April as a result of the losses it had endured. Riots in Russia in March led to the abdication of the czar, and when the Bolsheviks (see pp.376–77) seized power in November, they signed a ceasefire with Germany. The Italians had weakened the Austro-Hungarians, but when the Germans attacked in November, only the swift deployment of British and French troops saved Italy.

The Allies launched a new attack on the Western Front at Arras in April, and in July at Ypres. Both failed, with 250,000 casualties at Ypres.

US joins the war

Two events were to break the stalemate. In February 1917, Germany announced it would attack all foreign ships, in order to starve Britain out of the war. The threat to US shipping was clear, but Germany tried to divert American attention by encouraging Mexico to

Women at work

With men away fighting at the front, women were required to work in industry, services, and on the land. By the end of the war, one million British women worked in munitions (as pictured left) and engineering works.

attack the US. Publication of a telegram sent by the German foreign minister to Mexico outraged Americans, and in April the US declared war.

The second event was the mass use of tanks by the British at the Battle of Cambrai in November 1917. Tanks were one of the few developments in military technology during the war, along with airships and planes for reconnaissance, or bombardment.

The final nine months

In March 1918, Germany and Russia

signed a peace treaty at Brest-Litovsk. Germany now shifted all its troops to the Western Front, and attacked on March 21 before US troops arrived. But the Germans outran their supplies and the attack was halted on July 18. A mass tank advance by the British at Amiens on August 8 and French-US attacks to the south then forced the Germans back into Belgium.

Germany's Bulgarian allies sued for peace at the end of September,

while the Italians won a massive victory against the Austro-Hungarians in October. The Austro-Hungarian and Ottoman empires then both signed an armistice with the Allies. In Germany, food and fuel shortages led to the country collapsing from within. After the naval fleet mutinied at Kiel, Kaiser Wilhelm II abdicated and the new government agreed armistice terms. At 11 am on the morning of November 11, 1918, the war came to an end.



Land Army

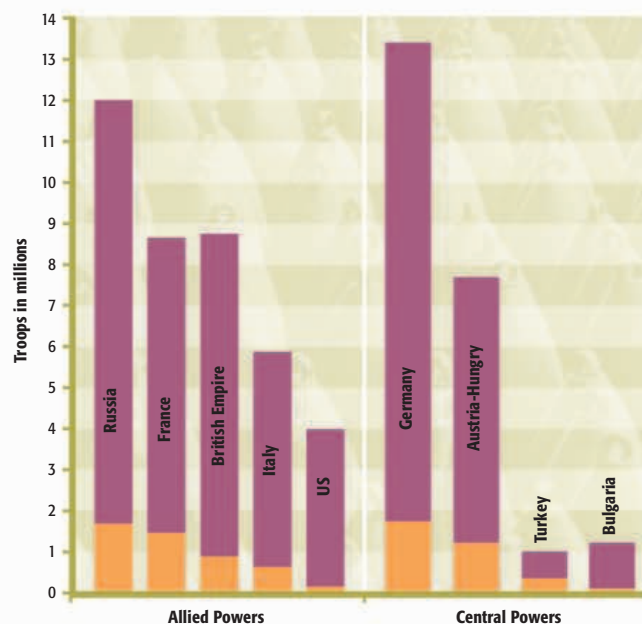
Women worked the land. It was vital both in the US and in Europe, where U-boat attacks and an economic blockade reduced food supplies.

KEY

■ Mobilized military
 ■ Military dead

War casualties

The human cost of the war was immense: a total of around 65 million men fought during the war, of whom 8.5 million died and 21.2 million were seriously injured. An estimated 6.6 million civilians also died from the fighting, or blockade, and disease.



AFTER

The war had short-term political effects in redrawing the map of Europe, but had longer-lasting social and economic consequences.

POSTWAR PEACE TREATIES

Under the **Versailles Treaty** signed in June 1919, Germany reluctantly accepted guilt for causing the war and agreed to pay **reparations** (war damages). It lost its colonies to the Allies as “mandates”—territories under the supervision of the League of Nations, an international organization founded to promote peace through diplomacy—and gave up territory to France, Belgium, Denmark, and Poland. Germany's armed forces were limited in size; the Rhineland was **demilitarized** and the industrial Saar region became a League of Nations mandate.

THE MAP OF EUROPE REDRAWN

The treaties of **St Germain** with Austria (September 1919), **Neuilly** with Bulgaria (November 1919), and **Trianon** with Hungary (June 1920) **redrew the map** of Central and Eastern Europe, with defeated nations paying war reparations. **Anschluss 392** >>, union between Austria and Germany, was forbidden. The **Treaty of Sèvres** with the Ottoman Empire was agreed in August 1920 but later rewritten at Lausanne in July 1923.

WOMEN AND WORK

The **mobilization of women** into war industries and agriculture temporarily raised their economic status, although most returned to work in the home at the end of the war. As a result of their war work, **women gained the vote** in Britain in 1918 and in America in 1920 **434–35** >>.

REMEMBRANCE

The profusion of red **Flanders poppies** growing along the Western Front after the war inspired the British Legion to sell paper poppies to raise money for injured soldiers. On or near **November 11** each year, commemorations are held across Europe to remember those who were killed or injured.

TOTAL WARFARE

World War I has been identified as the first “total war” in history, as the entire national economy, industry, and population were directed toward winning the war. British success in this **total mobilization** was one of the main reasons it, and the Allies, overcame Germany.



POPPY APPEAL

“No more slaughter, no more mud and blood...”

LIEUTENANT R. G. DIXON, BRITISH SOLDIER, NOVEMBER 11, 1918